

RESEARCH ARTICLE



From content moderation to *visibility* moderation: A case study of platform governance on TikTok

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Abstract

TikTok, a short-video app featuring video content typically between 15 and 60 s long, has become immensely popular around the world in the last few years. However, the worldwide popularity of TikTok requires the platform to constantly negotiate with the rules, norms and regulatory frameworks of the regions where it operates. Failure to do so has had significant consequences. For example, for content-related reasons, the platform has been (temporarily and permanently) banned in several countries, including India, Indonesia and Pakistan. Moreover, its Chinese ownership and popularity among underage users have made the platform subject to heightened scrutiny and criticism. In this paper, we introduce the notion of visibility moderation, defined as the process through which digital platforms manipulate the reach of user-generated content through algorithmic or regulatory means. We discuss particular measures TikTok implements to shape visibility and issues arising from it. This paper presents findings from interviews with content creators, which takes a user-centric approach to understand their sense-making of and negotiation with TikTok's visibility moderation. Findings from this study also highlight concerns that leave these stakeholders feeling confused, frustrated or powerless, which offer important directions for further research.

KEYWORDS

platform governance, platforms studies, qualitative, TikTok, visibility moderation

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INTRODUCTION AND BACKGROUND

As societies around the world grow ever more digitalised, our political lives and cultural activities have been increasingly configured into a platformed global ecosystem (van Dijck et al., 2018). Against this background, how platforms govern and how they are governed have vast political and societal impacts. Alongside established dominant platforms such as Facebook, Twitter and Google, one emerging platform whose platform governance has been under close scrutiny and criticism is the short video platform TikTok. In September 2021, TikTok reached one billion monthly active users globally (TikTok, 2021b), but the trajectory of TikTok's rise has been tortuous. The platform has been sued (Ridley, 2021), banned (Ellis-Petersen, 2020) and forced to sell (Allyn, 2020) in some of its most important international markets. Although geopolitics, especially the platform's Chinese roots, plays an important role in causing some of these controversies (Gray, 2021), TikTok's failure in governing content shared on its platform is also a crucial factor.

While content regulation is an important consideration on many digital platforms, certain platform specificities of TikTok have posed unique governance challenges. First is TikTok's young user demographic. Compared to other mainstream social media platforms, the user demographic of TikTok is quite young. It is estimated that over 60% of TikTok users are members of the Generation Z cohort (born between 1997 and 2012) (Muliadi, 2020). According to a 2021 usage report, 60% of US young adults (18–24) use the platform daily (TikTok, 2021a). In the United Kingdom, a survey conducted by the media regulator Ofcom (2021) reveals that almost half of children aged between 5 and 15 used TikTok to watch short video content in 2020. Because of its popularity with underaged users, TikTok has been under tight scrutiny from regulators from around the world. Since its launch, the platform has faced multiple high-profile lawsuits in the United States and Europe, the majority of which concern minor safety (Allyn, 2021; Ridley, 2021).

Second is the visual centrality of TikTok. As a platform hosting vast quantities of video content, TikTok is an obvious arena for propagating graphic, violent and pornographic content. In India, Indonesia and Pakistan, TikTok has been temporarily and permanently banned for hosting these types of content (Kaye et al., 2022). In comparison to text-rich or static image-centric platforms, such as Twitter and Instagram, moderating video content is more technologically demanding and time-consuming. The technological threshold to automate the tasks of detecting and removing videos is much higher than text or images (Gray & Suzor, 2020). As a result, human moderators play a crucial role in evaluating the 'appropriateness' of videos on digital platforms, including TikTok (Shead, 2020).

Another factor that contributes to the complexity of governance on TikTok is its virality-centric platform logic. Social media's platform logic can be defined as 'the strategies, mechanisms, and economies underpinning their dynamics' (van Dijck & Poell, 2013, p. 3). Content discovery on TikTok centres on its algorithm recommender system that pushes trending videos, which, in turn, shapes users' practices surrounding visibility. As Abidin (2021a) points out, on other mainstream social media, such as Instagram and YouTube, influence is 'persona-based or profile-anchored' (p. 79). On TikTok, however, a large follower base does not guarantee visibility. Creators' influence is based on the performance of individual posts. Therefore, creating viral content is the primary means for visibility and sociality (Zulli & Zulli, 2020). In attempts to achieve intentional or 'accidental virality' (Kaye, 2020), TikTok creators may seek to push boundaries, producing erratic or freakish content as well as harmful viral trends. The unpredictability and uncertainty of virality make it difficult for human content moderators to keep trends, particularly harmful or dangerous trends, in check. For example, in 2020 a video depicting an individual taking their own life spread quickly on TikTok and proved challenging to scrub from the platform as copies of the video

were continually reuploaded or inserted into other videos using TikTok's internal video creation features (Matamoros-Fernández & Kaye, 2020).

Considering the specificities and complexities of platform governance on TikTok, this study addresses issues concerning TikTok's governing strategies by focusing on its manipulation of content visibility. In the sections below, we first review key literature on content moderation. We then introduce the concept of *visibility moderation*. We define visibility moderation as the process through which digital platforms manipulate (i.e., amplify or suppress) the reach of user-generated content through algorithmic or regulatory means. We use this notion to conceptualise and underscore the measures TikTok implements to shape user activities and the connected issues arising from it. We then follow with an empirical discussion informed by 14 qualitative interviews with TikTok creators. We take a user-centric approach to understand TikTok content creators' experience and perception of the visibility moderation on the platform. Through insights from individual creators, we reveal how TikTok's practices and strategies to manipulate visibility are understood and negotiated by creators. We highlight concerns that cause these stakeholders to feel confused, frustrated or powerless. Visibility moderation encompasses the desire to be seen, the threat of invisibility, and logics of manipulation, suppression and amplification on digital platforms. This study offers directions for future work on content moderation and platform governance that foreground visibility.

LITERATURE REVIEW

Content moderation

Content moderation is an expansive and complex sociotechnical phenomenon (Gillespie et al., 2020; Gorwa, 2019) defined as the process in which platforms shape information exchange and user activity through deciding and filtering what is appropriate according to policies, legal requirements and cultural norms (Flew et al., 2019; Gillespie, 2018; Witt et al., 2019). It entails cooperation between human and nonhuman actors (Roberts, 2016), negotiation between platforms' epistemic authority and users' agency to resist (Cotter, 2019, 2021) and contestation between corporate interests and regulatory obligations (Suzor, 2019).

Throughout the 2010s, against a background of increasingly visible impacts of misinformation, hate crimes, online bullying and other toxic communication (Citron, 2014; Matamoros-Fernández, 2017; Noble, 2018; Saurwein & Spencer-Smith, 2020), how digital platforms moderate user-generated content has grown more relevant in public debates. In academic research, scholars from media and communication studies (Bucher, 2012; Gillespie et al., 2020), informatics (e.g., Binns et al., 2017; Pavlopoulos et al., 2017), and legal and policy studies (e.g., Helberger, 2020; Suzor et al., 2019) have developed extensive bodies of work to interrogate the complex systems of regulating online content, as well as social-political controversies emerging around these practises.

While voices pressuring digital platforms to regulate information and user behaviours continue to grow among regulators and the public, the academic community critically interrogates risks associated with platforms' growing power in arbitrating what is deemed to be 'irrelevant' 'false' or 'harmful' (Gillespie, 2020; Helberger, 2020). Related scholars problematise platforms' decision-making processes that introduce and reinforce prejudice and bias (Crawford & Gillespie, 2016; Katzenbach & Ulbricht, 2019; Wilkinson & Berry, 2020). For instance, in Crawford and Gillespie's (2016) study of user flagging on social media, the authors note that by outsourcing the moderation tasks to users, the flagging system imposes and legitimises platforms' own governing norms and logic. In their study of content

moderation on Instagram, Pinterest and Tumblr, Gerrard and Thornham (2020) use the concept of *sexist assemblages* to discuss how content moderation assembles human and technological elements to perpetuate normative gender roles and police representations of women bodies.

Algorithms have become ubiquitous in governing online communication. In response, scholars call for further research devoted to understanding the affective dimensions and perceptions of algorithmic moderation (Bucher, 2016). Algorithmic governance largely relies on 'black-box' machine-learning mechanisms to predict, classify and filter, introducing errors and opacity. The combination of algorithmic opacity and errors makes it difficult for users to hold the platform accountable. Inappropriate implementation of algorithmic content moderation also triggers senses of injustice, insignificance and distrust among users (Gillespie, 2020; Jhaver, 2019; West, 2018).

Prior research examining content moderation from users' perspectives investigates how users circumvent moderation systems (Gerrard, 2018; Zeng, 2020) and how they make sense of the opaque algorithmic systems by developing *folk theories* (Bishop, 2020; West, 2018) surrounding how systems of governance function. Bishop (2019) describes this form of unauthoritative knowledge about algorithmic systems created and shared by members of online communities as 'algorithmic gossip'. Bishop (2019) argues that algorithmic gossip is productive as a collective resource for knowledge production. One example of such algorithmic gossip is claims about *shadow bans*, or when platforms make users' content less likely to be seen without entirely removing it or notifying users (Cotter, 2021; West, 2018). Although social media platforms regularly deny the practice of shadow-banning, frequent creator disputes exemplify the power and information asymmetry between platforms and users (Cotter, 2021). Bucher (2016) argues it is important to understand how users imagine, perceive and experience algorithms—their *algorithmic imaginary*—as they 'not only shape the expectations users have towards computational systems, but also help shape the algorithms themselves' (p. 33). As we discuss in the sections below, these mutually shaping processes impact norms of moderation and visibility on platforms.

Visibility moderation on TikTok

Scholarly discussion of content moderation has traditionally focused on governing through removal (Jhaver, Bruckman, et al., 2019; Witt et al., 2019), filtering (Coluccia, 2020; Diakopoulos et al., 2012) and suspension (Thomas et al., 2011; Zeng et al., 2019). With the rise of algorithmic curation and recommendation, platforms can effectively regulate user-generated content without relying on deleting, but by intentionally promoting, amplifying and prioritising the visibility of content perceived as more relevant and appropriate (Chen et al., 2021; Gillespie, 2017; Suzor, 2019). Developing upon Bucher's (2012) conceptualisation of visibility as a disciplinary diagram, we propose *visibility moderation* as a lens to discuss the specificities of TikTok's content moderation mechanism. With a Foucauldian approach to visibility and governance, Bucher (2012) proposes a framework to examine the disciplinary power of social media content ranking algorithms. Using Facebook as a case study, Bucher (2012) argues that 'discipline denotes a type of power that economises its functioning by making subjects responsible for their own behaviour' (p. 1175). Social media exercise such power through 'threat of invisibility'—the constant possibility of becoming irrelevant and obsolete (Bucher, 2012, p. 1164). To remain or become relevant and noticeable, social media users adjust their behaviours, which Cotter (2019, p. 895) describes as 'play the visibility game'. Due to its particular content distribution architecture and platform culture, TikTok offers a productive case study to examine the disciplinary power of visibility.

On TikTok, the disciplinary power of visibility is embodied in its complex visibility moderation systems. At the macro level, TikTok implements platform-wide recommendation algorithms to personalise, curate and prioritise content. The main content viewing interface and landing page on the mobile app, the For You Page (FYP), pushes highly personalised feeds to individual users based on their interests and usage data. The FYP's underlying algorithmic recommender system, which we refer to as the *For You algorithm*, selects and matches videos with viewers by analysing engagement data of videos and user profiles (TikTok, 2020a). With its 'power to grant visibility' (Gillespie, 2017, p. 63), the For You algorithm detects which videos will make an impact on the platform. Within this system, one's video cannot make an impact on the platform unless it is 'favoured' by the For You algorithm. The power of this algorithm is vast, but so is the bias when considering the human subjectivity and values embedded in its design. Researchers have warned of human bias introduced in algorithmic governance, drawing attention to issues of fairness and efficacy (Gorwa et al., 2020; Zarsky, 2016). Fairness concerns the treatment of particular groups under digital platforms' governing systems and efficiency considers issues arising from inaccurate automated decision-making (Zarsky, 2016). These two closely intertwined issues are prominent in the governing logic of the FYP, exemplified in the ways the platform moderates visibility of the perceived vulnerable. In attempts to prevent online bullying, TikTok takes intentional measures to constrain the visibility of users who are deemed to be vulnerable to online bullying. Two sets of internal documents from TikTok were leaked and reviewed by reporters in 2019 and 2020 (Biddle et al., 2020; Köver & Reuter, 2019), revealing that visibility was deliberately restricted for videos featuring individuals with traits of 'unattractiveness' (e.g., in body shape, appearance, age) and developmental disorders (e.g., autism, Down syndrome). Visibility-restricted videos would not be recommended by the For You algorithm outside users' home country and were not allowed to be viewed over 10,000 times. Similar reports allege TikTok's For You algorithm has suppressed content that mentioned 'Black' or 'Black Lives Matter' in profiles on the TikTok Creator Marketplace (Brown, 2021) and was also accused of preventing LGBTQ+ content from going viral (Bacchi, 2020).

At the mesolevel, TikTok implements visibility moderation by nudging creator communities and users toward social justice campaigns, particularly those that promote the platform's overall corporate image by serving socially responsible goals. In the years since its international release in 2018, TikTok has become a prominent online space for youth-led activism, such as racial injustice and climate crisis (Kaye et al., 2022). Because hashtags that are officially endorsed by the platform are believed to be favoured by the For You algorithm, bandwagoning such campaigns has become a shortcut for creators to gain visibility (Hautea et al., 2021; Zeng & Abidin, 2021). From TikTok's perspective, by introducing and endorsing 'positive' trends, the platform can indirectly regulate content creation practices that benefit its own image. In early 2019, TikTok was warned and temporarily banned by the Indian government for hosting pornography and other forms of potentially harmful content (Kalra & Varadhan, 2019). In response, the platform launched a campaign called #EduTok that attempted to counterbalance perceived 'harmful' content with educational videos. Similarly, in response to the Chinese government's criticism over pornographic content, Douyin, the Chinese counterpart of TikTok, launched an initiative to cultivate and incentivise platform-wide trends of making more appropriate, patriotic content through a nation-wide 'positive energy' hashtag campaign (Chen et al., 2021).

On the microlevel, visibility moderation can also be exemplified by content creators and users' collective curation of comments. Through features such as 'like', 'dislike', 'upvote' or 'downvote', the practises of participatory ranking and curation of user-generated content are widely implemented on social media (Graham & Rodriguez, 2021; Massanari, 2017). On TikTok, video creators can directly moderate their comments and viewers participate in

ranking comments through interaction. The impact of the collective moderating of comments' is 'both semiotic and material' (Davis & Graham, 2021, p. 652). Semiotically, TikTok views, likes and replies connote approval, interest and controversy. Materially, such reactions are translated to metadata, which helps the algorithm make ranking calculations to determine how much exposure to grant certain types of content.

The concept of visibility moderation is a useful analytical framework, which helps to systematically delineate the complex system used by TikTok, as well as other social media, to 'discipline' content creation. In the following sections, we present an empirical study of visibility moderation on TikTok focusing on content creators' perspectives guided by three research questions:

RQ1: How do content creators make sense of TikTok's visibility moderation?

RQ2: How do content creators respond to the visibility moderation system?

RQ3: What are content creators' main concerns regarding TikTok's visibility moderation?

METHODOLOGY

We present an empirical study of creators both to illustrate the concept of visibility moderation and to centre users in scholarly debates of platform moderation and governance. We follow Ruckenstein and Turunen (2020) who advocate for research that moves to *re-humanize* platform operation, 'by re-establishing the human as a critical and creative actor in current and future platform arrangements' (p. 1027). Whereas Ruckenstein and Turunen focus on the complexities of practises of human content moderators, in this study we expand their rehumanizing approach by centring on the experiences of users, specifically content creators, who are at the receiving end of governance practises. As discussed above, platforms' design and implementation of content governance embed bias and errors. As Gillespie (2020, p. 3) notes 'the margin of error typically lands on the marginal: who these tools over-identify, or fail to protect, is rarely random'. Taking a user-centric angle to research content governance helps to illuminate power dynamics and injustices on platforms.

Data for this study were collected via in-depth semi-structured interviews conducted in January and February 2021. The interviews were conducted as part of a larger empirical study of TikTok platformisation. Twenty-two ($n = 22$) English-speaking TikTok creators from the United States, Canada and Australia participated in 45–90 min Zoom interviews to share insights regarding how they understood and navigated the infrastructures, markets and governance systems on TikTok. The focus of these interviews was broader than platform governance; however, interviewees' perspectives and experiences helped inform our conceptualisation of visibility moderation on TikTok. In this study, we draw on 14 ($n = 14$) interviews.

Interviewees were members of a smaller, discrete TikTok community purposively selected to study artistic content creators on TikTok. Interviews were audio-recorded, transcribed and analysed in NVivo qualitative data analysis software using a grounded approach to thematic coding (Corbin & Strauss, 2008). Qualitative coding of interviews proceeded in two stages. The first stage involved open coding, in which interview transcripts were annotated with labels and concepts that are potentially relevant to our three research questions. The second stage involved axial coding, which aims to refine, align and group codes established in the first stage. To do so, we established semantic relationships between labels we used for annotation and merged related labels into broader themes.

Interviews were conducted, transcribed and coded by one author. The transcript was reviewed by both authors, and the categorisation of thematic codes involved the participation, discussion and reconciling between both authors (McDonald et al., 2019). Each

interviewee provided informed consent before participating. The Interview questionnaire and consent forms were reviewed and approved by the interviewer's University human research ethics committee. As part of the consent process, interviewees were asked their preference to be named or remain anonymous. All interviewees consented to be named and to have their TikTok username included in publications, which we include below. In the following sections, we analyse creators' understandings of and experiences with visibility moderation, framed as sense-making, negotiation and concerns.

TIKTOK CREATORS AND VISIBILITY MODERATION

How do content creators make sense of visibility moderation?

In interviews, creators described their attempts to interrogate the black box For You algorithm in service of understanding and improving visibility. Creators' perceptions were informed by folk theories (West, 2018), based on their own experiences with virality or experiences shared by others. They also shared snippets of algorithmic gossip (Bishop, 2019) informed by conversations with friends and *mutuals*, the vernacular term for users who mutually follow each other on TikTok.

A recurring theme connected to visibility involved how creators with massive followings interpreted not being seen. A commonly cited explanation was that they had been shadow banned. Like on other digital platforms (Cotter, 2021; West, 2018), shadow bans are a nebulous concept on TikTok as Erynn, an American creator, summarised:

It's hard to trace exactly what constitutes a shadow ban but something doesn't add up when you have 600,000 followers and videos get like a hundred views... I've had multiple followers tell me that they have to seek out my content. they never actually see it naturally (Erynn, @rynnstar).

Some felt shadow bans were a natural occurrence on an algorithmically curated platform owned and operated by a commercial entity. Shout, an American creator, highlighted the impacts of feeling suppressed alongside what they viewed as TikTok's imperative to push trendy content that kept viewers watching:

I feel like to an extent TikTok does suppress videos that aren't as trendy as, you know, stuff that you would see coming from Charlie D'Amelio or some other people in that high follower count... I feel like my FYP went from seeing a bunch of different things to every third video being a verified celebrity, you know? So we're out here thinking, 'Oh, we can't compete with that.' I see friends who have quit TikTok because of that (Shout, @vocaloutburst).

Damoyee, an American creator, felt that she had not been shadow banned, per se, but was acutely aware that the success of her content depended on a mixture of user interaction and the For You algorithm:

The Watchers of the FYP help out by triggering the algorithm, even by just viewing the whole video and maybe like it or share it to three friends or even one. If you just have one friend, you can help them find their way through the FYP. I know if one person triggers it it might get sent to five more people (Damoyee, @damoyee).

Damoyee's view contests the power of the FYP as the chief 'governor' of visibility on TikTok, by reinserting humans, the watchers of the FYP, as gatekeepers. In a press release detailing certain aspects of how the FYP functions, TikTok (2020a, p. 1) notes that users watching a video in its entirety before scrolling down was a 'strong indicator of interest' that would lead to higher ranks and more likely to be recommended. This supports Damoyee's assertion and aligns with previous research on the role of user practices in participatory ranking systems (Graham & Rodriguez, 2021).

Interviewees also shared experiences of videos going viral that made them temporarily 'TikTok famous', showing up on the FYPs of thousands or sometimes millions of users seemingly all at once. After their visibility had been exponentially amplified by virality, they watched as their content found its way to FYPs far beyond their usual followers or TikTok communities. Violet, an American nonbinary creator who posted content about gender and sexuality on their account, questioned the efficacy of automated governing systems at the macro level that should, according to TikTok's guidelines and policies (TikTok, 2020b), prevent underaged individuals from using the platform at all. Violet explained that they had received numerous community guidelines violations on videos with no clear explanation as to why or what aspect of their video resulted in a violation. In one example, the specific guideline allegedly being violated was Minor Safety, a guideline that restricts sexual depiction of underaged users. Violet, who was over 18 years old at the time, explained that:

It's just so weird to me that me simply talking about how my videos are getting down, because my collarbones are showing gets taken down for something that isn't for minor safety (Violet, @violetbutnotaflower).

Violet's interpretation was that human viewers who sought to have Violet's content removed were reporting the videos for community guidelines violations aligns with previous findings on the strategic use of thin or ambiguous flags on digital platforms (Crawford & Gillespie, 2016). Ambiguous or erroneous flagging was also mentioned in the context of automated reports, as Tai, a Canadian creator, explained:

I have had a couple of community guideline violations. Not that many, like they used to happen a lot when I first started posting... But a couple of the other ones were just like, I don't know, [TikTok] automatically banned me a couple of times for saying the 'n-word.' And I'm like, I'm literally a Black person, leave me be (Tai, @thctai).

Previous research on African-American Vernacular English has explored the complex and nuanced use of the 'n-word' in American English (Jones & Hall, 2019), yet that complexity and nuance are lost in AI moderation. As with other visibility issues noted in interviews, the effects still disproportionately impact Black, Indigenous and people of colour on TikTok, as Alex, an American creator, noted:

The sense I've gotten is that TikTok just doesn't do a good of a job of giving people the tools to get rid of nasty people... A friend who was a Black creator made a music remix video where he sings the 'n-word' kind of in a comedic way. His video got taken down, but there are still white people saying the n-word and like not getting taken down. There's clearly a problem with the fairness of how things get reported (Alex @alexengleberg).

As West (2018) identified on Facebook, confusion and lack of transparency surrounding community guidelines violations on TikTok was often followed by subsequent violations.

Interviewees who had received violations explained that options for appeal were limited and equally confusing, as Jake described:

There's zero way to contact TikTok...There's no phone number. There's no nothing. I could get on the phone with someone or email somebody directly, but no, I'm basically it's within the app. Um, you press submit an appeal and it gives you like a character limit of like 50 or 200 characters to voice your complaints about the video (Jake @jakedoesmusicsometimes).

Jake's observation aligns with previous research on YouTube in which creators positioned the process of appealing platform community guidelines violations as being confusing and ineffective (Kaye & Gray, 2021) and offers little clarity or comfort when content is removed (Jhaver, Appling, et al., 2019). Visibility was cited as a motivating factor for creators to engage with the appeals, particularly when the videos removed were viral hits. These perceptions informed creators' actions and decisions to increase their own visibility or to intervene when they noticed TikTok's moderation failing to prevent harm and abuse.

How do content creators negotiate visibility moderation?

Alongside sharing their interpretation of how visibility moderation works on TikTok, interviewees also spoke about how they negotiated visibility on TikTok. As mentioned, TikTok practices visibility moderation on a macro level through its For You algorithm. For creators, landing their content on the FYP is crucial to their visibility on the platform. To improve their chance to be picked by the For You algorithm, or to become 'algorithmically recognizable' (Gillespie, 2017, p. 63), creators noted the ways in which they were encouraged to use certain hashtags either by the platform or other users. TikTok encourages users to incorporate trending hashtags by suggesting popular hashtags. Before publishing a video, creators have the option to add captions, mentions and hashtags. Typing any letter after pressing the '#' key displays suggestions for the most popular hashtag (i.e., typing 'f' displays suggestions #fyp, #foryou, #foryoupage next to the number of views associated with each). Other users can influence the decision to incorporate certain hashtags by repeated exposure or viral success.

Interviewees mentioned they would use hashtags that were trending, even those that had nothing to do with the video they were posting or hashtags that were nonsensical, such as in the case of #xyzbca, a trending hashtag with over 1.5 trillion views as of October 2021. Tai, a Canadian creator, admitted:

I have no idea what [xyzbca] means but I used to use it all the time... I've watched videos that have this hashtag and they seem to not have any correlation between them all. So I guess I thought I'll just start using it then. Right now I think I've been seeing 'Chobani Flip' or something. I know it's a brand but I have no idea why this yoghurt is showing up on all these random videos. It's just trending (Tai, @thcthai).

In instances where trending hashtags relate to specific branded marketing campaigns, such as in Tai's example of the yoghurt company Chobani, creators were helping brands market despite not receiving any compensation or creating content that related to the overall campaign; they participated to improve visibility.

Using unrelated hashtags to capitalise on trends and increase visibility, or hashtag hijacking, is not unique to TikTok (Bruns & Burgess, 2012), and has been previously found to

be a strategy to improve visibility on TikTok (Abidin, 2021b; Hautea et al., 2021). Shout (@vocaloutburst) recalled a period in late 2020 and early 2021 when #blackvoices and #blacklivesmatter were trending on TikTok, corresponding with the widespread social justice movement taking place around the world. While millions of videos included BLM hashtags, still more millions were examples of hashtag hijacking that had nothing to do with the cause.

Another popular TikTok-oriented group of hashtags, #fyp, #foryou or #foryoupage, were mentioned several times in interviews. While 'for you' hashtags are among the most widely used hashtags on TikTok, influencer marketing groups acknowledge their status as folk theories (Geyser, 2021) affirmed by interviewees who expressed their doubts that including 'for you' hashtags did anything to impact visibility.

Another perceived strategy to influence visibility was to post new videos every day:

I joined the cult of posting every day a long time ago. So many people were like 'post everyday post every day. It's good for the algorithm. And it lets you know that your pages are alive, post every day' (RJ @rjthecomposer).

RJ, an American creator, explained that he saw other users posting videos dissecting the TikTok algorithm and heard stories from mutuals that posting every day was a key to improving visibility. Despite posting something new every day, RJ immediately noticed that his videos were not being seen by his tens of thousands of followers. On the contrary, he remarked that often videos were only seen by a fraction of a percent of his followers.

Worth mentioning, interviewees' attempts to negotiate visibility moderation is not always for achieving wider reach. In contrast to strategies used to improve visibility, creators also described strategies they employed when they did not want to be seen by certain groups of users. For many interviewees, a viral video meant sudden exposure to new audiences who might be more likely to leave abusive comments, such as users out to troll creators or individuals with radically different social or political views. Sudden spikes could increase the likelihood of experiencing harassment or receiving spurious reports and also influence the kinds of content interviewees would see when scrolling their own feeds. To mitigate this, some interviewees described strategies to *reduce* their visibility to avoid harassment, reports or shifts in content recommendations. For example, Damoyee (@damoyee) would deliberately interact with videos that aligned with her personal views to see more similar content and cause a knock-on effect of her content being seen by other like-minded users as well. Others would post videos asking viewers to interact with their videos to navigate to help steer them back into familiar territories on the FYP where they were less likely to be seen by hostile users.

Strategies for negotiating visibility are crucial on platforms like TikTok that rely heavily on algorithmic curation. While many more visibility strategies have been offered by marketing firms and influencers, those strategies mentioned by interviewees demonstrate creators' attempts to 'play the visibility game' (Cotter, 2019, p. 895) and assert a sense of agency against the dynamic, black box For You algorithm. Discussions of creators' negotiated visibility on the platform also led to additional points of critique that creators felt were beyond their control, and possibly beyond TikTok's control.

What are content creators' concerns regarding visibility moderation?

Interviewees' concerns related to visibility moderation reflects broader societal issues and cultural norms that manifest on TikTok, as on other platforms (i.e., Katzenbach & Ulbricht, 2019; Noble, 2018; Witt et al., 2019). A principal source of frustration among creators was the high visibility of harmful comments that expressed racist, antisemitic, sexist and

homophobic views. Some interviewees had the impression that the problem of harmful comments was more prominent on TikTok than on other social media. Gabbi, an Australian creator, said she was shocked by:

...the audacity of commenters to just write literally whatever they want is so much stronger on TikTok than anywhere else. On Twitter, I find that people can track you pretty easily based on where you are, your workplace, like they can find you... Facebook it's obvious... because your whole personal profile is right there. But TikTok you can make 65 accounts and just comment whatever you want from all of them (Gabbi @fettucinefettuqueen).

Later in the interview, Gabbi mentioned that the verification requirements to create new TikTok accounts seemed more relaxed than on other platforms allowing users to create dozens of new accounts to circumvent bans or avoid the reputational consequences of commenting, such as losing followers for posting critical, argumentative or abusive comments. The practice of creating alternate accounts for the sole purpose of commenting, while not unique to TikTok, is another example of users moderating visibility (Cotter, 2019), in this case, to obfuscate links to their main account.

In discussing comment moderation systems, Stacey, a Canadian creator, compared TikTok to YouTube:

YouTube does a really, really good job with [comment moderation]. In YouTube Studio you can see comments that didn't make it through because they were maybe hateful, maybe marked as spam, maybe something else. But on TikTok there's nothing... there's no one going into your comments, deleting them. If you're getting plenty of hate, no one will do anything about it, except for the creator (Stacey, @staceyryanmusic).

This also came up in the context of minor safety, given that TikTok is home to an infamously young user base (Muliadi, 2020; TikTok, 2021a). Violet explained that they sometimes felt the need to self-censor content geared towards more adult audiences after repeatedly finding ostensibly underaged users appearing in their comment section. Violet commented on the irony that their videos had been erroneously flagged or removed for Minor Safety, while minor users were evidently able to use TikTok and comment on Violet's videos.

When my videos blow up then they have thousands of comments... I don't read them all, but I try. I look at people's accounts. I see who's following me. There were people who were under nine years old, like six or seven maybe... I don't know how they have the access to even be on the app (Violet, @violetbutnotaflower).

In response to this problem, some interviewees explained that they felt a need to take personal responsibility to moderate their comment sections. Rachel, an American creator, discussed the burden of moderating anti-Semitic content shouldered by individual creators:

I do think that, that the anti-Semitism on TikTok has run rampant at times. I understand why others would [leave the platform]. I know it has been exhausting for other creators that I follow to be faced with what feels like attacks on all sides (Rachel, @rvmillz).

Emerson, an Australian creator, explained that he felt it was his responsibility to moderate his comment section even when the harassment was not addressed to him directly:

I've probably read more comments than I should have... I don't think things ever get deleted. There were times earlier, before I started really deleting comments there would be... argumentative comment[s] and then other people on TikTok would be having that argument and I can see it happening. It was a time where I didn't have to moderate but I felt a sense of responsibility that it was on my video and it's an argument that's going absolutely nowhere (Emerson, @emersonbrophy).

Emerson explained that arguments and abusive comments became more frequent the further he waded into American political debates with his videos. As noted, the majority of creators interviewed as part of the larger research programme on TikTok were musical creators. Many professed that they normally posted videos that were uncontroversial; they just enjoyed playing music on the app with their friends. The creators quoted in this study, however, described more instances of controversy due to the politically charged nature of their content. Discussions about racism, homophobia and misogyny on TikTok reflected broader feelings that content moderation is unfair and inefficient (Zarsky, 2016), as Erynn explained:

... being a Black woman on the internet in general you're always a target for harassment. Lots of people seem to love the opportunity to take you down or to criticise you for various things or to be racist... I think the more frustrating thing is that a lot of times you don't feel like you're given appropriate support from the platform because you report racist videos and stuff to TikTok and oftentimes they don't take it down (Erynn, @rynnstar).

In addition to concerns about comments, creators pointed to ways in which the report function could be used as tools to inflict harm and abuse, particularly for Black and Queer creators. We adopt the term *report bombing* to describe instances of coordinated mass reporting by human users to have content flagged or removed. The notion of online bombing is a form of brigading that has been used, for example, to describe review bombing, in which groups of users artificially deflate review scores for various types of media (Wordsworth, 2019). Like other folk theories, interviewees' could not provide direct evidence that they had been the victim of report bombing but it figured into their attempts to make sense of otherwise nonsensical reports they had received.

Creators explained that report bombing was, in their view, attacks from trolls intended to reduce their visibility or their likelihood of showing up on others' FYPs. In one instance, despite self-identifying as 'not a very political person' Anthony (@ewokbeats), an American creator who normally only posted videos playing drums, shared that he had a video removed for community guidelines violations in which he voiced his support for the Black Lives Matter movement. He explained that the video had received multiple reports for violations that had nothing to do with the content of his video, such as hateful behaviour, harassment and bullying. Other interviewees described the same phenomenon, which they took as evidence that the reports were being made by other users as opposed to automated systems or teams of moderators. Like on other digital platforms, violating community guidelines on TikTok carries increasingly severe consequences for repeat offences, as Violet described:

One of my favourite creators is trans and Black[...] Recently she had her account banned because she had exceeded the amount of community guidelines violations, and then they deleted her account (Violet, @violetbutnotaflower).

Beyond the risks of impacting visibility or resulting in accounts being taken down, report bombing can delegitimise internal methods of platform governance. Interviewees were exasperated that reporting was effective at removing their own videos that did not violate guidelines but ineffective at removing content they reported for being harmful, problematic and legitimately in violation of community guidelines. These individuals questioned why to even bother reporting legitimately abusive content while they were spending time trying to appeal illegitimate abusive reports.

These concerns illustrate tensions produced by heightened visibility on TikTok. Whether strategic or unexpected, creators may find themselves seen by unintended audiences of age-inappropriate or hostile users that can result in flags, reports or bans. In addition to reiterating the contested nature of algorithmic governance (Katzenbach & Ulbricht, 2019), these criticisms also provide a human dimension of the impacts of moderation from a creator standpoint, to complement research on content moderators (Ruckenstein & Turunen, 2020).

CONCLUSION

In this paper, we propose the concept of visibility moderation as a dimension to explore, understand and critique platform governance. Rather than emphasising how platforms make rules about what is not to be seen, visibility moderation concerns a wider range of practises and logic involved in suppressing and amplifying the reach of certain user-generated content. Alongside gatekeeping videos for individual users, visibility moderation disciplines content creators through their desire to be seen, as well as through the threat of invisibility.

To illustrate and problematise visibility moderation, we empirically examined TikTok content creators' interpretation and negotiation of visibility through in-depth interviews. First, creators in this study made sense of visibility moderation on TikTok by sharing gossip and lore. Their understandings were rationalised by personal experiences, such as with shadow bans, and reinforced by policy violations, such as being reported for community guidelines violations. Second, creators attempted to negotiate visibility using strategies that might improve their chances of landing on certain users' algorithmically curated feeds while attempting to avoid landing on the FYPs of unwanted others. Third, creators raised concerns with visibility moderation, such as a lack of human or automated oversight of comments and the prevalence of reporting systems being used as tools of suppression. We present these limited understandings, strategies and concerns as instructive starting points for further critique, policy work and research on visibility moderation.

TikTok content creators' strategies to negotiate visibility demonstrates the effects of visibility as a disciplinary diagram. As discussed in section 'Literature and review', social media platforms govern through visibility, especially through the *threat of invisibility* (Bucher, 2012). As indicated in our findings of content creators' attempts to negotiate the influence of their content, the desperation to be seen and the threat of invisibility are evident. On the one hand, strategies reported by creators showcase a sense of agency in negotiating their influence. On the other hand, creators directly pointed to information and power asymmetries between users and platforms (Cotter, 2021). Relying on folk theories, creators employed strategies to improve their chances to appear on the FYP, while encountering what they perceived as unjust and unfair treatment by the platform and other users. Overall, participants expressed feelings of confusion, desperation and powerlessness towards moderating visibility on TikTok.

While visibility moderation is not unique to short video platforms, TikTok is a unique site to explore visibility governance due to the centrality of its algorithmic recommender system and the many different approaches creators take to interrogate black boxes, negotiate power and mitigate harms on the platform. This study joins previous research that calls for

more ground-level stakeholder involvement to shape understandings of platform governance (Cotter, 2021; Edwards & Moss, 2020; Kaye & Gray, 2021). With algorithms becoming the norm to moderate content, platforms are increasingly ruled by statistical mindsets, which carry errors and result in human costs (Gillespie, 2020). Future research should continue to centre focus on the people carrying the burdens and suffering the costs. There are no easy ways out or clear-cut solutions to address the concerns associated with visibility moderation on digital platforms. Further research can productively explore visibility moderation to inform scholarly debates, make policy recommendations and influence public deliberation over platform governance.

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